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The Maasai of Matapato

Author(S): Spencer, Paul

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DISBANDING THE MANYATA VILLAGES • PHASE VI. THE MIGRATION TO THE VILLAGE OF ENKARRER

By the time the 1977 *eunoto* in Matapato had reached its concluding stage, the long summer dry season had again begun and dispersal was an overdue relief, even for the moran. At the previous *eunoto* about seven years earlier, however, conditions had been quite different, and the attitude of the moran towards dispersal was more spirited.

Case 34 .

The *eunoto* festival for the Meruturud^L had taken place in a period of good times with a large gathering, and they remained *in situ* for several months. After the migration to the village of *enkarrer*, the moran refused to disperse. They maintained that as the privileged defenders of the land and sole owners of their manyata, they had a right to remain together for as long as they chose, regrowing and rebraiding their hair as in the past. Their firestick patrons of Terito age-set systematically coerced them from this defiant stand. They first pointed out that in the past, a prompt dispersal from the village of *enkarrer* had always been observed and was a necessary part of *eunoto*. Then they threatened simply to abandon the rebellious moran to their own ways. They would refuse the moran further ceremonies so that they would remain and die as moran with no prospect of elderhood. Then, striding away from the meeting, the patrons left the moran with little option other than to rush up with fistfuls of grass, forcing the patrons to recant, but at the same time submitting to the inevitable. They dispersed to their separate manyata areas almost at once.

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Organized Ceremonial

Through *eunoto*, the whole age-group are mustered as never before in their existence, and the principal dance that expresses the triumph of this mustering, as in war, is their *enkipaata*. In precolonial times, a successful *eunoto* is said to have culminated with a flamboyant raid against some established enemy of the Maasai. This flamboyance is evoked by the term used elsewhere in Maasai for this raid, coupled with a vow to excel in fighting. It is the term that in Matapato refers to their diehards, *iloontorosi*. The raid is seen essentially as a display of supremacy at a supreme moment for the age-group, and not as a desperate bid by cattle-hungry marauders; although this may have been true of some of the younger or less successful moran. According to informants, the majority of moran by this stage in their careers would have established themselves sufficiently to have lost their aggressive edge. Memory of this tradition is vaguer in Matapato than among the Purko, for instance. Nevertheless, Case 34 suggests that even in modern times, the Matapato *eunoto* can still unite and enthuse an age-group of moran and goad them to assert themselves in a crowning display.

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DISBANDING THE MANYATA VILLAGES

Nowadays, each manyata village is formally disbanded quite soon after  165 the return from *eunoto*. The disbanding ceremony (*enoonkureeta*) repeats the earlier scene at the inauguration of the manyata when the patrons marked their arrival with a display of authority. The patrons are expected to come with long whips and an assortment of warrior headgear in the spirit of a burlesque on moranhood. Again they play on the apprehensions of their hosts in a mood of mock aggression. Yelping, singing their past moran songs, they crack their whips as they approach the manyata, and hurl mock curses and accusations of incest. Their aim is to frighten the manyata-mothers who are less certain that these mock curses are harmless play. The mothers urge the moran to join them with fistfuls of grass, imploring the patrons to eat the meat and drink the beer that has been prepared for them. As in the inauguration ceremony, the elders show some reluctance and turn their backs contemptuously on the moran. Their strategy is to prolong this show of irritation until the show of contrition by the moran is at least equally convincing. Once this is achieved and the patrons allow themselves to be persuaded to accept the hospitality, their curses earlier in the day can have no effect. However, by this point, they have achieved their purpose. The abusive idiom of the patrons recalls the first forest feast when joking abuse between moran and their mothers was indirectly at the expense of their absent fathers, whom they were about to desert for the manyata. At the disbanding ceremony, the moran are on the point of leading their mothers back to their fathers' villages. The joke is now turned against them with the patrons (many of them their fathers) hurling sexual abuse at their expense.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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